

Chapter 124 - Conspiracy

Jiang Li was coughing violently. Ning Fuyi couldn't bear to listen and was about to jump down directly, but reason immediately stopped her.

The snake woman's magical power was unfathomable. Even if she could defeat her, this fortress was filled with roaming giant snakes everywhere. With only herself fighting, it really wasn't safe. She feared that by then, not only would she fail to rescue Jiang Li, but she might also harm her instead.

So she stopped her movements and continued to spy.

Fortunately, although this Black Scales treated Jiang Li roughly, she didn't take her life.

"Jiuying!" She called in her mind for a long while before Jiuying's listless response came.

"What is it?" Jiuying said. "This miasma is truly harmful. This old lady has turned into a qilin¹ and can't change back for the time being."

"Good that you're alive." Ning Fuyi said. "Are you with the Divine Venerable?"

"Except for you and that boy from the Hua family, everyone else is here. We followed the marks you left all the way and are now hiding outside this fortress." Jiuying answered. "Have you found Jiang Li?"

"She's right below me." Ning Fuyi quickly told her what she had just seen, making Jiuying tsk several times.

"Poor Medical Immortal Jiang, such a tender-hearted and gentle woman, to suffer such torment. Sect Leader Tang wants you not to act rashly for now. The gate has opened again - we're coming in."

Ning Fuyi hummed in agreement, then dismissed distracting thoughts and redirected her attention back to the stone house.

Jiang Li was still prostrate on the ground, her coughing gradually easing. The brief suffocation made her eyes glisten with tears as she silently sniffled.

"A hundred years ago when I first met you, you were still a girl with apricot eyes and peach cheeks, with thick black hair so dense it curled, and hairpins couldn't even hold it up." Jiang Li seemed to feel no pain, resting her forehead on her scarred hands. "You became master's disciple and timidly called me senior sister."

"I wondered then why someone's hair could be so beautiful, with eyelashes long like cattails that trembled into one's heart with every movement."

"Stop talking nonsense!" Black Scales gripped her dagger tightly, her lush eyelashes covering her eyes.

"Although you weren't skilled in medical arts, you were diligent and studious, often reciting medical texts by moonlight. I couldn't bear to see you studying alone, so I often pretended to be cultivating and went to the mountaintop to meditate when the moon was bright. Thus, under the bright moon, you and I didn't say a word, yet accompanied each other through countless entire nights."

"In this world, the strong are revered, and the art of medicine² is most useless. Even if you're making things up, make them believable." Black Scales was obviously unmoved. She pulled off the cloak from her shoulders and threw it onto Jiang Li. "I still have important matters to attend to. Take care of yourself."

"You learned medical arts for your clanspeople!" Jiang Li raised her voice. "You said your clanspeople all suffered from stubborn ailments, and you didn't want them to endure suffering, so you became master's disciple!"

"I was born alone - where would I have clanspeople?" Black Scales was already impatient. She drew her ancient silver dagger and stabbed it into the ground next to Jiang Li's neck. "If you keep babbling, I'll definitely finish you off!"

"You've been spouting this nonsense for days now. Haven't you said enough? I'm definitely not some snake demon. Open your eyes wide and look carefully - do I have even a trace of demonic aura?" She raised her hand to pull out the dagger, sliding the blade across Jiang Li's delicate throat, leaving a thin red mark.

"I don't want to kill you, but if you keep talking nonsense, I can't guarantee I'll be able to hold back." Black Scales neatly flicked the dagger back into its sheath, glanced at her once, and stepped out.

Seeing her figure disappear, Ning Fuyi transformed into points of light and squeezed through the door crack, appearing beside Jiang Li and quickly helping her up.

Jiang Li's body was soft and limp, with almost no strength to support herself. Ning Fuyi immediately felt heartbroken and quickly drew out immortal power to inject into her body. After about half an incense stick's time, Jiang Li opened her eyes again.

Her bright and beautiful eyes had been soaked in tears for too long and couldn't see very clearly. She struggled to make out the face for a moment before murmuring: "Could this be Zhuangzi's butterfly dream³? I'm actually seeing Ning Fuyi's face."

"What dream? It's me." Ning Fuyi waved her hand to break the iron shackles on her feet. After observing the red marks on her wrists, she angrily cut away the restraints on her hands. "Did that black snake capture you? Since she no longer recognizes you, why waste words on her!"

"If one day the Divine Venerable also forgot you, could you just let her go?" Jiang Li smiled with curved brows, struggling to support her body.

Ning Fuyi's eyes flickered - she was defeated and didn't argue further, supporting her with one hand: "The Divine Venerable and the others are all outside. We obtained your blood letter from the Jiang family and came to Xuanyuan Kingdom to try our luck."

"I really didn't expect you would come to rescue me..." Jiang Li lowered her eyes, enduring the pain with a smile. "I deliberately approached her, wanting to find out why she has no memory and such a changed temperament."

"Why didn't you tell someone? If you couldn't get the letter out, wouldn't you die here in vain?" Ning Fuyi said.

"After all, it's my personal matter. I didn't want to involve others too much." Jiang Li stood up with a pale face. "But after being captured, I observed for a long time and discovered this matter is definitely not that simple, but an extremely vicious conspiracy."

"What?" Ning Fuyi looked up.

"Did you see that tall tower in the courtyard and the blue flames in the furnace?" Jiang Li picked up the cloak and wrapped her scarred body. "Those aren't ordinary flames, but Infinite Ghost Fire⁴."

Infinite Ghost Fire... Ning Fuyi found it familiar but couldn't remember for the moment.

"This thing has long been unknown to the world. I only heard master mention it in lectures. Legend says that before heaven and earth opened, there were pure and turbid extremes in chaos, and these extremes gave birth to this fire. It's said to be able to burn all things and never extinguish once ignited."

"Later, when heaven and earth first opened, this fire seed also disappeared without a trace."

Ning Fuyi suddenly remembered why it was familiar - this name had been mentioned in the "Divine Demon Manual" that Fengdu gave her, but the ancient text was too obscure and difficult to understand, so her memory wasn't deep.

She immediately took out the "Divine Demon Manual" and flipped through it rapidly, finding the page that recorded Infinite Ghost Fire.

"That's not right. It says here that Infinite Ghost Fire is white as snow, so why are those flames blue?" Ning Fuyi pondered, then relaxed her brow. "Could it be that the fire in the furnace hasn't been refined yet?"

If so, it would make sense. Those black snakes continuously threw the corpses of intruders into the fire to temper real Infinite Ghost Fire.

Fortunately, it hadn't been refined yet, or even moving the entire East Sea over wouldn't be enough to extinguish it.

"Those snakes have almost no consciousness. This fire should be Penglai's handiwork." Ning Fuyi quickly put away the book. "Medical Immortal Jiang, your injuries are quite severe. Rest here first while I find a way to extinguish that fire seed."

"My injuries don't matter..." Jiang Li had only said half her words when they suddenly heard a loud crash from nearby, and the ground beneath their feet trembled.

Ning Fuyi had no time to think further and immediately flashed out of the stone house. From afar, she could see rolling smoke and dust, the tall tower collapsing, and heat baking the unreachably high stone walls overhead. The ghost fire's light illuminated the fortress like broad daylight.

Two figures were already flying in mid-air, their combat creating earth-shaking noise, with fierce winds overturning the corridors on both sides. Countless brick and tile fragments fell into the furnace, splashing up scalding ghost fire.

"You evil creature, allowing snake demons to kill disciples from my sect - today I will definitely capture you for Penglai to interrogate!" The one fighting Black Scales was Tang Wenshu. He wielded his heavy sword so densely that sword light crisscrossed like a net, forcing Black Scales to dodge left and right.

At the same time, the sounds of battle spread into the shadows, and dense rustling sounds came from all directions.

"So many snakes!" Baili Shiqi cried out in alarm. She shook the bell in her hand and placed it behind her ear, then ice-blue light broke through the air, severing several black snakes that had somehow crawled to her feet.

"Be careful!" Liu Wenzhu was also greatly alarmed. She swung her hand to smash the head of a bowl-thick snake and retreated in panic.

Looking around, the yellow-brown ground was now covered in black. Countless snakes intertwined together, surging toward them like a tide, making Liu Wenzhu's legs go weak.

Ning Fuyi thought "This is bad" and swept past the mess like a gust of wind, rushing toward the still blazing furnace. However, halfway there, a giant snake descended from above. Just as she was about to resist, she collided face-to-face with a bloody maw. A qilin's roar tore through the sky as it trampled the giant snake into a brick wall with one claw.

"You go find the Divine Venerable - leave this to me!" Jiuying's echoing voice rang out, then her fire-breathing tail swept past Ning Fuyi's waist, throwing her out of the snake swarm without explanation.

When Ning Fuyi came to her senses, she had already tumbled twice in the air before landing steadily in front of Chu Qingqiu.

"We must extinguish that fire." Ning Fuyi went straight to the point without saying a single unnecessary word.

Chu Qingqiu breathed a sigh of relief upon seeing her. Without asking further questions, she leaped onto the furnace. However, after just one glance at the ice-blue flames, her expression became tense.

The two recited the same incantation in their hearts, and torrential water gushed forth, falling into the flames with a hissing sound.

Although it was effective, they had not cultivated water-based techniques after all - they were capable but not proficient, and it wasn't enough to extinguish the fire seed. Ning Fuyi decisively withdrew her gesture and said to Chu Qingqiu: "Hold on for now - I'll go get Sect Leader Tang!"

"Be careful." Chu Qingqiu looked at her deeply.

Ning Fuyi smiled at her, then reached out to smooth her hair. After feeling Chu Qingqiu actively lean into her palm's warmth, her heart softened, but she still turned and disappeared into the chaotic flying sword lights and snake shadows.

Jiuying was still dealing with the endless stream of giant snakes. Baili Shiqi had pulled out some magical artifact and was chasing the snake swarm, cutting them like vegetables.

Liu Wenzhu was originally afraid of snakes, insects, rats, and ants, and had fallen somewhat behind. Ning Fuyi was about to help her when another figure landed in front of her, using hundreds of vine tendrils to sweep away the snake swarm.

It was the eldest Hua son, Hua Feihua. After all, he was a young sect leader with skilled techniques and outstanding immortal power, Ning Fuyi thought.

Just then, Tang Wenshu had used a move called "Sword Rain Flying Flowers." Ning Fuyi flashed to his side and said quietly: "Sect Leader Tang, I need your help to extinguish the ghost fire, or it will definitely leave great trouble!"

Tang Wenshu withdrew his heavy sword upon hearing this, then chopped down a flying snake and frowned: "But this person is difficult to deal with. You..."

"Don't worry." The woman's black clothes rustled as she smiled with curved lips.

Tang Wenshu nodded and raised his hand: "Take care."

After saying this, he soared up and landed beside Chu Qingqiu. Water like a great river bursting its banks rushed from his sleeves, and the water vapor condensed into rolling clouds.

Ning Fuyi withdrew her gaze, looking at the silently standing woman with black hair and white skin in the distance, and slowly raised her Emei thorns. Thunder immediately rumbled overhead.

Black Scales' eyes darkened for a moment before she charged toward her.

Footnotes:

1. **Qilin (麒麟)** - A mythical Chinese creature, often translated as "Chinese unicorn" but more like a dragon-horse hybrid, considered a benevolent creature and symbol of prosperity.
2. **Art of medicine (岐黄之术)** - Refers to traditional Chinese medicine, named after the Yellow Emperor (Huangdi) and his physician Qi Bo, who are considered the founders of TCM.
3. **Zhuangzi's butterfly dream (庄生晓梦)** - Famous philosophical allegory by Zhuangzi where he dreams of being a butterfly, then wakes unsure whether he's a man who dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming of being a man. Used here to express disbelief at what one is seeing.
4. **Infinite Ghost Fire (无极鬼火)** - A legendary fire from primordial chaos that can burn anything and never be extinguished once lit.